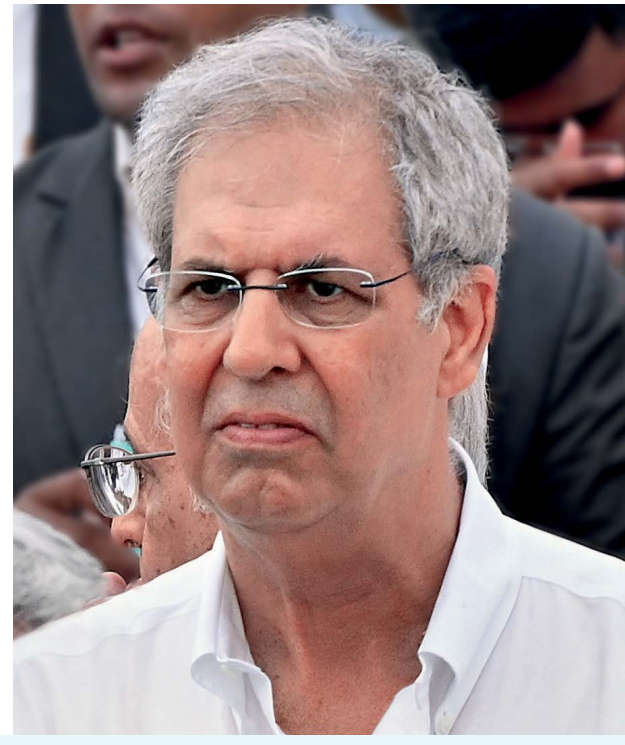
GLASSHOUSE: GANDHIS GO GEN Z *PG 19*

GRAPHIC: AI EYE ON JANTAR MANTAR *PG 22*



BANDEEP SINGH

POWER EQUATION N. Chandrasekaran, Chairman, Tata Sons; (right) Noel Tata, Chairman, Tata Trusts



MANDAR DEODHAR

TATA GROUP

SEARCH FOR A SUCCESSOR

N. Chandrasekaran decides to step down as Tata Sons chairman in February 2027, ending months of speculation and bringing the group's leadership question in focus

By M.G. ARUN

NATARAJAN CHANDRASEKARAN will step down as chairman of Tata Sons when his current term expires on February 20, 2027, ending months of speculation over whether he would be reappointed after a decade at the helm. The issue gained urgency because his reappointment as a director of Tata Sons, the holding company of the Rs 26.5 lakh crore Tata Group, was due to come up at the August 18 annual general meeting and was necessary for him to continue as chairman.

In a statement on August 12, Chandrasekaran, 63, said that the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust—the two principal trusts of Tata Trusts, which owns 66 per cent of Tata Sons—had unanimously recommended a five-year extension for him. The resolution had been placed before the Tata Sons board on February 24. "However, the proposal was not carried through because one of the board members did not support it; and in the absence of unanimous support, I chose to defer the decision," it read.

Although Chandrasekaran did not name anyone, the reference was widely seen as pointing to Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata. Having initially backed a third term for Chandrasekaran, Noel later reportedly raised concerns over the performance of several group companies, heavy capital spending on new ventures such as semiconductors, and the group's broader strategic direction.

The split within the group's top leadership became public last year when trustees Mehli Mistry, Pramit Jhaveri, Jehangir H.C. Jehangir and Darius Khambata opposed the reappointment of veteran industrialist Venu Srinivasan and former defence secretary Vijay Singh to the boards of the two principal trusts. The Centre had to intervene, with home minister Amit Shah and finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman calling Noel, Chandrasekaran and